

PHYSICAL AND EMOTIONAL SELF-CARE

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Understand the connections among medical issues, self-care, and addiction.
2. Reduce the impact of medical problems on recovery and relapse potential.
3. Understand and participate in the medical management of physical health problems.
4. Examine daily use of time and identify both healthy practices and areas for improvement.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE MEDICAL ISSUES

- Alternative Methods for Managing Pain
- Assessing My Needs
- Building My Support Network
- Coping with Addiction and Chronic Pain
- Coping with Addiction and Other Medical Problems
- Coping with Stress
- Creating a Preliminary Health Plan
- Eating Patterns Self-Assessment
- Handling Crisis
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- Learning to Self-Soothe

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Borderline Traits
- Chronic Pain
- Depression
- Eating Disorders
- Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)
- Relapse Proneness
- Self-Care Deficit—Primary
- Substance-Induced Disorders
- Substance Intoxication/Withdrawal

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Physical and Emotional Self-Care” activity is meant for clients who tend to neglect this area and are at greater risk of relapse as a result. Its approach is to focus the client’s attention on self-care and guide him/her in a systematic assessment of his/her needs, habits, and resources, then to create a structured self-care plan that can be used as a gauge to evaluate follow-through. Follow-up activities might include keeping a self-care log and reporting back to the therapist or group on progress, an assignment to survey role models on their own self-care practices, and using the information collected in this activity in completing the “Personal Recovery Planning” activity.

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There is a link between taking poor care of oneself and relapse. When people abuse alcohol, other drugs, or practice other addictions, they often neglect basic self-care for both their physical needs (nutrition, sleep, exercise) and their emotional needs (safety, competence, sense of value, acceptance, ability to control life events). This exercise will help you recognize both what you are now doing to take care of yourself and areas where you still have room for improvement.

1. What things are you doing today to take care of yourself physically?

2. Physical self-care tracking chart (please keep a record for the next 7 days).

Date	What I Planned to Do	What I Did	What Helped	What Got in the Way	How I Can Overcome in Future
<i>Ex.</i>	<i>Take a walk</i>	<i>No exercise</i>		<i>Procrastinated</i>	<i>Do first thing in A.M.</i>
<i>Ex.</i>	<i>Eat balanced meal</i>	<i>Ate breakfast</i>	<i>Planned meal</i>		

3. Please answer these questions about your emotional self-care.

a. What emotional needs do you have which are not being met today?

b. What emotional needs did you try to meet with addictive behaviors in the past?

c. What methods or resources now help you provide for your emotional needs?

d. What types of emotional pain or deprivation are you able to avoid or cope with?

e. What additional methods or resources do you think you need to help get your emotional needs met? Where and how can you learn these methods or get these resources?

Be sure to bring this handout back to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.